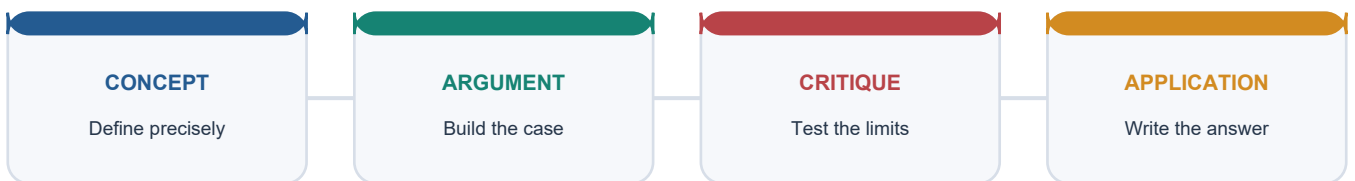


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

UPSC Qualifying English - Question-Only Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

UPSC Qualifying English - Question-Only Practice Workbook

Question-only diagnostic and full-length practice. Complete each paper before consulting the separate solutions document.

PART 01 - 01 Foundation-Test

Time: 90 minutes | **Marks:** 85 | Attempt without consulting Core files. This is a grammar/usage diagnostic, not a reading, précis or essay paper. Write an error code where requested: AGR, CNT, PRO, TNS, COND, ART, PREP, PHR, MOD, PAR, PUNC, SPL, WF or VAR.

A. Identify function in context (6 marks)

Name the function of the bold word.

1. The **committee** submitted its report.
2. **They** accepted the recommendation.
3. It was a **difficult** decision.
4. The officer spoke **calmly**.
5. Citizens **expect** timely service.
6. We need **some** evidence before deciding.

B. Nouns and pronouns (10 marks)

Correct each sentence and add the most relevant code.

1. One of the applicant have withdrawn.
2. The police is investigating the complaint.
3. She gave me two useful advices.
4. We bought three furniture for the office.
5. Between you and I, the proposal is unsafe.
6. Every applicant must bring his identity card.
7. The report, that identified the error, was published yesterday.
8. Candidates who have identity cards may enter.
9. The committee have submitted its report as one body.
10. The scissors is on the table.

C. Agreement, tense, conditionals, articles and determiners (14 marks)

Correct each sentence and add the most relevant code.

1. A number of student is absent.
2. Neither the manager nor the clerks is ready.
3. The news are encouraging.
4. She has finished the report yesterday.
5. By the time we arrived, the meeting already ended.
6. I am knowing the answer now.
7. If I would have known, I would have called.
8. If she had accepted the post, she will live in Mumbai now.

9. When I will arrive, I will call you.
10. He went to hospital to visit his friend.
11. She is teacher in a village school.
12. Honesty is best policy.
13. Few candidates understood the question, but a few attempted it.
14. He bought a European map and an hourglass.

D. Prepositions, verb patterns, phrasal verbs, conjunctions and modifiers (10 marks)

Correct each sentence and add the most relevant code.

1. She agreed the proposal.
2. The officer discussed about the proposal.
3. The unit comprises of five sections.
4. I have been waiting since three hours.
5. We must comply to the order.
6. The office provided meals workers.
7. She turned down it without explanation.
8. Although it was late but they continued.
9. The job requires planning, coordination and to monitor.
10. Walking to the office, the rain began.

E. Punctuation, capitals and spelling (10 marks)

Rewrite correctly.

1. after the interview we returned home
2. the proposal was ambitious however it lacked funding
3. The reports that were incomplete were returned
4. Riya has only one brother who lives in pune
5. the causes of the crisis are unemployment inflation and weak demand
6. the officers report was delayed
7. no the answer is not correct
8. the inquiry had one conclusion postpone the launch
9. its important to check every candidates identity card
10. The accomodation was definately insufficient.

F. Word formation, confusables and exact vocabulary (10 marks)

1. The committee reached a ____ after debate. (decide/decision)
2. The measure may ____ hardship. (alleviate/alleviation)
3. The official was ____ during negotiations. (discreet/discrete)
4. The storm did not ____ the inland district. (affect/effect)
5. Please buy some _____. (stationary/stationery)
6. The principal acted on a sound _____. (principal/principle)
7. Give an antonym of *scarce*.
8. Give a near-synonym of *prudent* suitable in formal prose.
9. Use *feasible* in one sentence so that its meaning is clear.

10. Use *cut corners* in one sentence so that its idiomatic meaning is clear.

G. Correction and accepted variants (5 marks)

Correct only if necessary. If no change is needed, write **acceptable** and state why.

1. Each candidate must bring their admit card.
2. The reason is because funding was delayed.
3. He was angry at the contractor.
4. She provided the workers meals.
5. The committee are divided in their views.

H. Transform without changing meaning (10 marks)

1. As soon as the meeting ended, the members left. (Use *no sooner...than.*)
2. If you do not revise, you will forget the rules. (Use *unless.*)
3. The box is so heavy that I cannot lift it. (Use *too...to.*)
4. Although he was tired, he continued working. (Use *in spite of.*)
5. The police arrested the accused. (Passive voice.)
6. The board gave Riya a prize. (Passive voice.)
7. He said, "I am ready." (Indirect speech.)
8. The teacher said to Riya, "Please do not leave early." (Indirect speech.)
9. The guide said, "The Earth moves around the Sun." (Indirect speech.)
10. Only Ravi solved the problem. Rewrite to mean that Ravi solved only the problem, not another task.

I. Meaning and natural use (10 marks)

Give the meaning and use each naturally in a sentence.

1. at sea
2. a thorn in the flesh
3. move heaven and earth
4. A stitch in time saves nine.
5. All that glitters is not gold.

Then add question tags:

6. They will attend the programme, ___?
7. Let us revise the answer, ___?
8. She is not ready, ___?
9. Open the door, ___?
10. There is a problem, ___?

Scoring and retry gate

Mark with answer-keys/01_Foundation-Test-Key.md. A valid listed alternative receives full credit. Record every missed error code, not only the mark.

Result	Action
77-85 and no zero in B, C, D or H	proceed to timed mixed revision
68-76	redo only missed-​code drills after 24 hours, then retake a fresh version

Result	Action
below 68 or any critical zero	revisit the named Core owner, make an error log, and retake after 24 hours

Critical families are countability/pronouns (B), tense/conditionals/articles (C), verb patterns/modifiers (D), and voice/narration/transformation (H). Two consecutive timed passes at 77+ are required before attempting the full-length mock.

PART 02 - 02 Full-Length-Mock

Time: Three Hours | **Maximum Marks:** 300 All questions are compulsory. Write answers in English. Observe specified word limits. Do not consult Core files or the key while attempting.

Q1. Essay (100 marks)

Write an essay in about **600 words** on any one:

1. Convenience without responsibility weakens citizenship.
2. Efficiency is not the same as effectiveness.
3. Certainty can be a barrier to learning.
4. Reading is an exercise in freedom.

Q2. Comprehension (5 × 15 = 75 marks)

Read the passage and answer in clear, correct and concise language. Where a question has components, the split shown is a **practice diagnostic**, not a claim about UPSC's internal marking.

Public debate often treats maintenance as an unimportant activity that begins only after a new road, school, irrigation channel or digital platform has been created. Construction attracts attention because it produces a visible object and a convenient date of inauguration. Maintenance, by contrast, is repetitive, dispersed and difficult to celebrate. Yet the quality of public infrastructure depends less on the moment at which it is opened than on the regularity with which it is inspected, repaired and adapted.

Neglect rarely causes immediate collapse. A blocked drain, a small crack, an outdated software component or a missing health worker may initially seem tolerable. Each defect, however, reduces the system's ability to absorb pressure. When heavy rain, unusually high demand or an emergency arrives, several minor weaknesses interact and produce a major failure. What appears to be a sudden disaster is often the delayed result of ordinary neglect.

The problem is partly financial. Capital expenditure and maintenance expenditure are commonly planned through different administrative processes. A department may obtain funds for a new asset but lack predictable money for staff, spare parts, local supervision or periodic renewal. The problem is also institutional. When responsibility is divided among several agencies, each may assume that another will act. Citizens then face a confusing chain of offices, while no official possesses both the authority and the incentive to correct the defect.

Good maintenance requires information from users. A village water committee may notice declining pressure before a distant engineer does. Bus passengers know which routes regularly fail. Nurses can identify equipment that is technically present but functionally unusable. Such information becomes valuable only when institutions provide a simple reporting channel, acknowledge complaints and publish what action was taken. A complaint system that merely generates a registration number creates an appearance of responsiveness without actual repair.

Maintenance should therefore be understood as a form of public ethics. It respects the money already spent, protects users from preventable harm and extends the life of scarce assets. It is also more equitable than repeated replacement, because poor communities are least able to find private alternatives when a public service fails. A state that maintains well demonstrates that it values continuity, reliability and the daily experience of citizens, not only the announcement of new projects.

1. Why does construction receive more attention than maintenance? (15)

2. Why is a “sudden disaster” often a misleading description of failure in this passage? (15)
3. State the financial causes (7) and institutional causes (8) of poor maintenance identified by the author.
4. What does “an appearance of responsiveness” mean in context? (7) What must occur before user information becomes effective? (8)
5. Give a suitable title to the passage (4) and explain the author’s attitude to maintenance with two grounded reasons (11).

Q3. Précis (75 marks)

Make a précis of the following passage in about **one-third** of its length. **Do not give a title.** Use your own language. Record source, target and final word counts on rough work.

Modern life rewards speed. Messages travel instantly, goods arrive rapidly and public opinion forms before facts have been fully examined. Speed can save lives, reduce costs and connect people who would otherwise remain isolated. It is therefore tempting to treat every delay as evidence of incompetence. Yet many valuable forms of work depend not on slowness for its own sake but on the time required for attention, verification and judgment.

A doctor must sometimes act immediately, but a diagnosis based on incomplete evidence can expose a patient to needless treatment. A judge should not prolong a case through avoidable procedure, but a decision made without hearing the parties is not efficient justice. A journalist should report urgent events, but publishing an unverified claim can damage reputations faster than any later correction can repair them. In each case, the proper objective is not maximum speed. It is timely action combined with sufficient care.

Digital systems have intensified the conflict. Their interfaces encourage rapid response: click, approve, forward, accept. Because the physical effort is small, the intellectual consequences may also appear small. An official can approve a file without reading its annexures; a citizen can share a rumour without checking its source; a consumer can accept terms without understanding them. Technology shortens the distance between impulse and action, but it does not remove responsibility for the result.

Institutions can respond by distinguishing delay from deliberation. Delay occurs when work remains unattended, responsibility is unclear or procedure serves no useful purpose. Deliberation occurs when relevant evidence is gathered, competing claims are compared and reasons are recorded. The two may consume equal time while having entirely different value. A good institution should eliminate idle waiting while protecting the stages at which thought improves the decision.

This requires measurement that goes beyond simple disposal counts. If an office is rewarded only for the number of cases closed, difficult cases may be rejected quickly or recorded as resolved without solving the underlying problem. If a school measures only examination completion, it may ignore whether students have understood. If a hospital measures only patient turnover, it may overlook recovery and follow-up. Numbers are necessary, but the chosen number silently defines what workers will prioritise.

Individuals also need habits that resist careless speed. Before forwarding information, one can examine the source. Before replying in anger, one can pause. Before making an irreversible choice, one can ask whether important alternatives have been considered. These pauses are not signs of weakness. They are small forms of self-government.

The mature alternative to haste is not endless postponement. It is disciplined timeliness: acting as soon as the necessary knowledge, authority and safeguards are present. Societies that learn this distinction can benefit from speed without allowing speed to become their master.

Q4. Usage and Vocabulary I (25 marks)

A. Correct the sentences (10 × 1)

1. One of the files are missing.
2. She is capable to solve the problem.
3. The officer discussed about the proposal.
4. Neither of the alternatives are acceptable.
5. He has returned back from Delhi.
6. The furniture in these rooms are old.
7. I have been waiting since three hours.
8. No sooner the bell rang than the students left.
9. The reason is because funding was delayed.
10. Each candidate must bring their admit card.

B. Supply the missing preposition (5 × 1)

1. comply ____ the order
2. abstain ____ voting
3. responsible ____ the delay
4. distinguish X ____ Y
5. insist ____ verification

C. Use the correct verb form (5 × 1)

1. By the time we arrived, the meeting ____ (end).
2. If she ____ (work) regularly, she will improve.
3. The officer ____ (read) when the call came.
4. The Earth ____ (move) around the Sun.
5. He ____ (serve) here since 2022.

D. Give antonyms (5 × 1)

transparent, scarce, voluntary, rigid, temporary

Q5. Usage and Vocabulary II (25 marks)

A. Transform without changing meaning (10 × 1)

1. The team completed the survey. (Passive)
2. She said, "I have submitted the form." (Indirect)
3. As soon as the rain stopped, work resumed. (Hardly...when)
4. If you do not listen, you will misunderstand. (Unless)
5. He was so weak that he could not walk. (Too...to)
6. He is honest. He is efficient. (Not only...but also)
7. Although the task was difficult, she completed it. (In spite of)
8. They are ready, ____? (Question tag)
9. The office was closed because it was a holiday. (Begin with **It being...**)
10. Only Meera checked the accounts. Rewrite to mean that Meera checked only the accounts.

B. Use each word in a sentence showing its meaning (5 × 1)

prudent, alleviate, reluctant, impartial, feasible

C. Choose the correct word (5 × 1)

1. The new policy will (complement/compliment) the existing scheme.
2. Please buy some (stationary/stationery).
3. The principal acted on a sound (principal/principle).
4. The storm did not (affect/effect) the inland district.
5. The official was (discreet/discrete) during negotiations.

D. Use each idiom/proverb in a sentence (5 × 1)

1. at sea
2. cut corners
3. a blessing in disguise
4. a stitch in time saves nine
5. all that glitters is not gold

PART 03 - 03 Full-Length-Mock-2

Time: Three Hours | **Maximum Marks:** 300 Independent of Mock 1. All questions are compulsory. Write answers in English. Observe specified word limits.

Q1. Essay (100 marks)

Write an essay in about **600 words** on any one:

1. Rules acquire legitimacy when they are understandable as well as enforceable.
2. The ability to listen is a form of public responsibility.
3. Progress should enlarge human judgement, not merely human choice.
4. A city is made not only by buildings but by shared habits.

Q2. Comprehension (5 × 15 = 75 marks)

Read the passage and answer in clear, correct and concise language. The component splits are for post-test diagnosis, not a claimed official marking scheme.

Public discussions of data often begin with collection: how many records an institution holds, how quickly it can receive them and what patterns a computer can detect. Collection is important, but it is only the first step. A school may know attendance, a clinic may know the number of visits and a city may know the location of traffic congestion. These facts become useful only when they are accurate, interpreted carefully and connected to a decision that someone is responsible for making.

The danger is not merely that a record may be wrong. It is also that a correct record can answer the wrong question. A school that measures only attendance may overlook whether students understand their lessons. A clinic that counts visits may miss whether treatment was completed. A city that measures average traffic speed may improve one road while making walking more difficult or unsafe elsewhere. Numbers simplify a complex reality so that it can be compared. They should not be allowed to replace the reality they simplify.

Good use of data therefore requires judgment. Staff must ask what a measure leaves out, whose experience it does not capture and what behaviour it may unintentionally encourage. A target can improve performance when it clarifies a public purpose. It can also distort performance when workers are rewarded for meeting the number rather than achieving the purpose. The distinction is especially important where people cannot easily complain or choose another service.

This is not an argument for abandoning measurement. Without records, failures may remain invisible and public claims cannot be tested. The task is to combine numerical evidence with observation, explanation and a route for correction. Institutions should publish enough information for their work to be examined, but they should also be willing to revise a measure when it begins to conceal the problem it was meant to reveal.

1. What four conditions must be met before collected facts become useful? (3 + 4 + 4 + 4)
2. Explain the claim that a correct record can answer the wrong question. Use one example from the passage. (8 + 7)
3. What does “replace the reality they simplify” mean? (8) Why is this a risk for public services? (7)
4. Infer the author’s tone towards targets. Give two reasons from the passage. (3 + 6 + 6)
5. Give a suitable title (4) and state the author’s purpose in using the school, clinic and city examples (11).

Q3. Précis (75 marks)

Make a précis of the following passage in about **one-third** of its length. **Do not give or suggest a title.** Use your own language.

People often describe silence as the absence of communication. In public life, however, silence can carry several meanings. A person may be silent because she agrees, because she fears a consequence, because she has not understood the discussion, or because the setting gives her no realistic opportunity to speak. Treating all silence as consent is therefore convenient but unsafe.

Meetings illustrate the problem. A chairperson may invite comments and receive none. That result does not prove that everyone has been heard. Participants may lack the technical language to challenge a proposal, may not wish to disagree in front of a superior, or may believe that a decision has already been made. The formal opportunity to speak is valuable, but it is not identical with a fair opportunity to influence the outcome.

Listening is consequently more demanding than waiting politely while another person talks. It requires asking whether the question was clear, whether relevant people were present, whether a different format would permit candour and whether reasons offered by a minority have been recorded. These steps can slow a decision, but they may prevent a faster decision from resting on an avoidable misunderstanding.

Listening also has limits. No institution can postpone action until every disagreement disappears, and some decisions must be made quickly. The aim is not unanimity. It is to distinguish informed acceptance from silence produced by fear, confusion or exclusion. A public body that makes this distinction can decide firmly while remaining open to correction.

Q4. Usage and Vocabulary I (25 marks)

A. Correct the sentences (10 × 1)

1. The list of eligible candidates are displayed outside.
2. She has been living here since five years.
3. The report was divided between four sections.
4. He insisted to inspect the original file.
5. Neither Rohan nor his friends was willing to wait.
6. The manager suggested me to apply again.
7. Having finished the audit, the errors were reported.
8. I prefer walking than taking a crowded bus.
9. Every employee should submit their forms by Friday.
10. The committee discussed about the delay.

B. Supply the missing word or preposition (5 × 1)

1. The policy is intended ____ reduce waste.
2. She is familiar ____ the procedure.
3. The decision was based ____ incomplete information.
4. He was accused ____ ignoring the warning.
5. The matter is different ____ the earlier case.

C. Use the correct verb form (5 × 1)

1. If the train ____ (leave) before we arrive, we will take the next one.
2. She ____ (prepare) the note when the visitors arrived.
3. By next June, they ____ (complete) the bridge.
4. Neither of the answers ____ (seem) convincing.
5. I ____ (not see) him since the meeting.

D. Give antonyms (5 × 1)

deliberate, expand, conceal, inferior, temporary

Q5. Usage and Vocabulary II (25 marks)

A. Transform without changing meaning (10 × 1)

1. The board will announce the result tomorrow. (Passive)
2. The teacher said, "Do not copy the answer." (Indirect command)
3. As soon as the officer arrived, the meeting began. (No sooner...than)
4. If you do not check the source, you may share an error. (Unless)
5. The bag is so heavy that she cannot carry it. (Too...to)
6. He is diligent. He is careful. (Not only...but also)
7. Although the route was long, they continued walking. (In spite of)
8. Let us begin now, ____? (Question tag)
9. Because the road was narrow, the bus moved slowly. (Begin with **Being...**)
10. Only the chairperson signed the minutes. Rewrite to mean that the chairperson signed only the minutes.

B. Use each word in a sentence showing its meaning (5 × 1)

coherent, mitigate, tentative, resilient, obsolete

C. Choose the correct word (5 × 1)

1. The speaker tried to (elicit/illicit) a response.
2. The new building will not (exceed/accede) the permitted height.
3. The witness gave a (credible/credulous) account.
4. The medicine had an immediate (affect/effect).
5. The teams will work (together/altogether) on the project.

D. Use each idiom/proverb in a sentence (5 × 1)

1. look before you leap
2. a thorn in the flesh
3. know the ins and outs
4. where there is a will, there is a way
5. go berserk